

Rep. Tom Emmer on The Matt Gaetz Show

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MATT:

Joining us now is the Republican Whip, the third-ranking official in the Republican House leadership and a man I proudly voted for to be Speaker of the House one time, Tom Emmer. Tom, great to have you back on the program. How is Congress reacting to this assassination attempt in Washington over the weekend?

REP. TOM EMMER:

You know, it's interesting. Different people process it differently. You watched the president the other night. He was the picture of calm. And then there were others in the room that obviously were running for the exits and diving under tables. I think it's a reminder for everybody, the president's been through this. I mean, he's had more assassination attempts than anybody. And one of which was just, we're very lucky that he's still here. That's by the will of God. He recognizes that. I don't think a lot of those people in the room, Matt, a lot of those correspondents, they've never experienced that. And I think that had a sobering impact on a bunch of them. And I think that's why the president kind of threw out an olive branch after in his press conference when he said he had a big speech that he was going to give. And maybe in the future he'll do it just a little differently now that, I'm going to add some words, now that people have experienced what some of this awful rhetoric causes.

MATT:

You go to about three dinners every single night. You're in Washington. You speak to groups that bring their members to town to talk to their elected representatives. And there's not a lot of security in these ballrooms, in these restaurants where leaders frequent. Are you concerned about safety in Washington, D.C. after this event?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I think we should all be aware all the time. I mean, I had Maxine Waters years ago come into Minneapolis and literally call on people to confront us, us being primarily Republican elected officials, wherever we are, right? In the restaurant, on the street. That's the wrong kind of rhetoric. It comes from the left, Matt. You don't hear Republicans saying this kind of stuff. That's the issue. Did we have security the other night? They had layers of security, layers of security, law enforcement everywhere. These people who are deranged and somehow get activated, that doesn't just happen overnight, Matt. That happens over time. And the people closest to them should be able to identify those red flags and report them to the appropriate persons. I think that's the bigger issue, but we should always be aware. You know this as well as I do. Not everybody's going to always be happy with the positions we take. With that kind of rhetoric, you always have to have your head on a swivel and you should be aware of your surroundings at all times.

MATT:

We get fewer death threats in this job as opposed to the last one, which is why we admire you for being there. And now you are one of the Republican House leaders working to get us out of this DHS shutdown. And I'm

wondering, following the weekend's events, are you seeing any more movement from these Democrats who are unwilling to fund the Department of Homeland Security?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Yeah, well, if it's happening, no, I have not seen it. That doesn't mean there aren't some quiet conversations going on that I'm not aware of yet. As you know, everybody's flying back into town today. Those of us that were here for the correspondence dinner weren't many. So we'll have a better idea on that probably later tonight after we've had the conference meeting that we're going to have tonight, some other things that are going on. But I do, I'm afraid, Matt, that we are going to have to do this with just Republican votes. My grandfather's Democrat Party has gone off the rails. The DHS bill, like the other 12 bills, was pre-negotiated with Republicans and Democrats in a bicameral, bipartisan way. It was an agreement that Chuck Schumer and Democrats reneged on when it got over to the Senate. And then they passed this bill in the middle of the night with no one on the House floor, I'm sorry, on the Senate floor, and sent us over a bill that's missing two important pieces, Customs and Border Patrol and the Immigration and Customs Enforcement sections of the bill. Totally inappropriate.

MATT:

Yeah. I want to ask you about another important piece of legislation. The House has moved legislation to deport illegal alien fraudsters, 186 Democrats voted for it. You're the former head of the political wing of the Republican team in the House. What percent of the Republican ads in the midterms should focus on fraud as a central issue?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I would focus on fraud as your primary issue, because that's what this is about, waste, fraud, and abuse. And I think you said 186 of them voted for it. They voted against it.

MATT:

I'm sorry, yes. 186 Democrats voted against holding illegal alien fraudsters accountable.

REP. TOM EMMER:

By the way, if they're illegal, they shouldn't be here anyway. They should be deported, which is why we've got a bill called the Scam Act, which I think is the next step. If you have been a naturalized citizen in this country for 10 years or less, and frankly, I'd like to make it longer, and you commit fraud, you take advantage of the generous American taxpayer, you should be denaturalized and shipped back to wherever the heck you came from. You don't belong here.

MATT:

Yeah. And if Democrats aren't for that, it'll be a tough sell, I would think, to independent voters, to suburban voters, to just reasonable people that think that a social safety net should work for vulnerable Americans. Now, you mentioned this reconciliation bill. It looks like the last big bite at the apple to get meaningful policy reform done before the midterms. We heard Senator Fetterman say we now need the ballroom at the White House as a result of these revelations and the violence over the weekend. Do you think there's any way to include the ballroom in the reconciliation bill?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, see, we're calling it an appropriations funding bill, even though it's reconciliation, because we're going to have to pass it with only Republican votes, Matt. They are already working on the quote-unquote reconciliation bill. They're calling it 3.0, they being the speaker and Steve Scalise and many others in our conference. I don't know that this is the last one that leaves the station, because they're pretty serious about getting that third one done. This again is just a funding bill for two pieces of the DHS appropriations bill that the Democrats reneged on. It's very narrow. The instruction, I understand, is for \$70 billion for those two things, so I don't know. But you know this, Matt.

MATT:

Do you have the votes for that, Mr. Whip? It's your job to count the votes. Do you have them? And if not, what are any of the issues that could potentially be divisive within the caucus you help lead?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, it's really going to be right now. Do you put all kinds of additional stuff? Jason Smith on Ways and Means wants to put some additional tax stuff. Jim Jordan's got some ideas. August Pfluger's got some ideas from RSC. There are a bunch of members that would like other things in this bill. The question is, does it get passed with other things on it? That remains to be seen. That is the debate, though, that's taking place. You can love it to death. You can love a bill to death. You can love it so much that you drive the coalition away.

MATT:

Final question for you. The Rules Committee is working through the farm bill. I know that's important to a lot of farmers. I noticed the White House branded their outreach to farmers only farms. How's that been received in Minnesota?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, look, our farmers, Matt, are desperate right now. And I want to give President Trump credit because in the big, beautiful tax cut bill, as he now calls it, he passed the investment part of this farm bill. Twenty percent of it was the investments, major investments. Now you're talking about 80 percent, which is policy. Our farm community, our rural community, ag community across this country is desperate for this type of leadership. And they're all Republicans. I mean, it shouldn't surprise us that 92 percent of farm country in America is represented by a Republican. So I think what the president is saying is we're with you when he says farm only. He's not talking about.

MATT:

It's only farms, Tom. You can't invert those or it loses the whole pun. Republican whip Tom Emmer. Thanks so much for joining us. I look forward to checking back in with you soon.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Great, Matt. Take care.

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